India's foreign transhipment requirement is currently estimated at about 3 million TEUs annually, roughly the load of 200 large container ships. Much of this traffic is handled by the ports of Colombo and Singapore, at an estimated annual cost of $200 million (Rs 1,800 crore). While Vizhinjam International Seaport can currently handle 1 million TEU of transhipment cargo, the Great Nicobar ICTT is projected to handle 4 million TEU in Phase 1 by 2028, scaling up to 16 million TEUs over 25 years. Strategically located just 40 nautical miles from the Strait of Malacca, it aims not only to capture India-bound transhipment traffic but also to draw some international cargo now routed through Colombo and Singapore—provided it proves cost-effective. Union shipping, ports and waterways minister Sarbananda Sonowal told INDIA TODAY, "ICTT will make us a leading maritime nation. We have to develop facilities so that shipliners come and berth here. Berthing here means we are growing our income. I'm creating employment opportunities."

A. Balasubramanian, a project financier and lawyer, finds the economic logic compelling. "With India's trade growing, we require such outlets. Transhipment requires a high degree of expertise. The project cost is very high, and the returns do not come up so fast, but the project will have a multiplier effect," he says. If the project is abandoned, India will lose a huge amount of traffic, he adds, "and our plan to decongest our existing ports will not materialise. With a port, a whole ecosystem develops—banking, insurance, ship broking, customs and so on". Sceptics, however, question whether projected volumes justify the cost—or the environmental trade-offs. Maritime policy expert and former naval officer Abhijit Singh argues that the rationale for locating an ICTT on Great Nicobar is flawed. Unlike Colombo, he notes, it has no urban centre, industrial hinterland or logistics backbone to sustain port-led growth. Geography itself, he suggests in an incisive media column, could become its greatest handicap in building a cost-effective feeder operation. "The Great Nicobar project is undoubtedly ambitious," he says. "Yet ambition, divorced from economic and logistical realities, is no recipe for success. A world-class port with few takers will yield neither influence nor development. It will, instead, stand as a cautionary lesson in misplaced ambition."

## UNDER THREAT
## INDIGENOUS TRIBES

**Two indigenous communities, the Shompen and the Nicobarese, inhabit Great Nicobar Island. The Shompen, who number around 300, live deep in the interiors, are not routinely in contact with the outside world, and are primarily hunter-gatherers. The Nicobarese, numbering around 450, lead a semi-nomadic life along the eastern coast. Following the 2004 Indian Ocean tsunami, they were relocated here from the island's western coast.**

**THE FEAR: Ecologists warn the project could see an influx of outsiders into Great Nicobar, disrupting the protected lives of indigenous tribes, particularly the Shompen. The Nicobarese allege they were asked to cede ancestral land on the island's western coast, promised to them after the tsunami. Tribal Council chairman Barnabas Manju says he withdrew consent to the project after learning the extent of the ancestral land being sought, but is yet to hear from the Centre. Clearances needed under Forest Rights Act have been challenged in the Calcutta HC.**

**THE RESPONSE: Tribal affairs ministry says 751 sq. km is designated as a tribal reserve on the island. However, 84.1 sq. km of the proposed project area overlaps with the reserve, even as the latter gets land elsewhere. A 50-year Tribal Welfare Plan is a mandated condition for environmental clearance.**



## THE STRATEGIC IMPERATIVE

Meanwhile, defence analysts say the strategic importance of the Andaman and Nicobar Islands cannot be overstated. Straddling key sea lanes of the Indian Ocean, the archipelago is a natural outpost for monitoring, and potentially countering, Chinese maritime activity. India already operates the integrated Andaman and Nicobar Command (ANC) at Port Blair, which acts a maritime surveillance hub, tracking naval movement in the eastern Indian Ocean and the Strait of Malacca. It also acts as a forward operating base toward Southeast Asia, keeping a close eye on Chinese naval deployment in the region. Further south, India also maintains a naval air station, INS Baaz, at Campbell Bay on Great Nicobar, which supports maritime patrol, surveillance missions and limited fighter deployment.

The islands are undergoing steady military upgrades, including modernisation of airfields and jetties, enhancement of logistics and storage facilities, and establishment of a strong surveil-